2011. In April 2015, *The Times of India* quoted Minister of State for Home Affairs Haribhai Parthibhai Chaudhary as saying that the Upper Assam Leading Committee of the CPI-Maoist is 'presently operating in Assam and Arunachal Pradesh and has been involved in the looting of weapons and extortion activities in the local villages'.[15] The minister went on to say that the CPI-Maoist had been engaged in recruitment and training of cadres for its units in Assam. 'These cadres have been involved in extensive propaganda against mega dams in Assam. Against this backdrop, the Assam-Arunachal border has emerged as another theatre of Maoist activity,' the minister said.[16]

India's Maoist movement may be dwindling and is not as strong as it was in the first decade of the twenty-first century. But it is still active mainly in the tribal belt in central India—and it has been able to find new fertile ground for its revolutionary message among some tribal communities in Arunachal precisely because the state is developing fast, and hydroelectric power generation is part of economic development. As Akhil Ranjan Dutta, a professor of political science at Guwahati University, explains, the projects have been marred

> by pursuing aggressive corporate friendly development paradigm as is evident in the case of commissioning of large river dams in the region. Relative egalitarian societies have … witnessed a transition towards hierarchical class divisions once the political elites have joined hands with the Indian ruling class … along with it has evolved a new middle class—the contractors, clerks etc. who have gradually disassociated from the communities.[17]

The extent of Maoist penetration of Arunachal became known in August 2011, when arrested Maoist cadres told their interrogators that they used to hold regular 'revolutionary meetings' at their hideouts in Lohit and Lower Dibang Valley districts in Arunachal. Such meetings were attended by between 150 and 200 villagers and cadres, the captured Maoists said.[18] The CPI-Maoist has, over the past few years, also established links with ULFA and leftist rebels in Manipur. According to ULFA commander Paresh Baruah, 'if the Maoists can launch a successful war against the Indian state, it will be beneficial for ULFA. We have a strategic understanding with the Maoists on our common enemy.'[19] Most Manipuri rebels have been leftists since the days of their hero Hijam Irabot, who formed the first revolutionary movement in the state in the 1940s.